

Information Architecture

A Quick Overview

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Topics

- **Defining IA**
- Elements
- Process



Information Architecture

- The application of principles of **design and architecture** to digital information
- The **structural design** of **information systems**, interactive services, and **user experiences**
- The combination of **labels, organization, search, and navigation** systems within websites
- The art and science of **labeling and organizing** web sites, intranets, online communities, and software to support **findability** and **usability**



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- The **organizational framework** for a body of information, providing **context, awareness of location**, and **sustainable structure**



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- The **organizational framework** surrounding information, providing **context, awareness of location, and sustainable structure**



IA in Context

Information Theory	<i>Bits & bytes, entropy, error-correction, encryption, compression, etc.</i>
Information Architecture (IA)	Organizing information to be found & used
(Library &) Information Science (LIS)	<i>Information storage and access, often academic or scientific</i>
Information Management	<i>Like LIS, with more computer/database stuff</i>
Knowledge Management	<i>Systems for capture & sharing of knowledge</i>
Taxonomy	<i>Structure for information sets</i>
User Experience Research (UXR)	<i>User studies & systems, user interfaces (UI)</i>
Product Design	<i>Design</i>

Topics

- Defining IA
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Topics

- Defining IA
- **Elements**
- Process

- Labels & Vocabulary
- Search & Navigation
- Metadata
- Style

Elements

Labels

Vocabulary

Search

Navigation

Metadata

Style

A label is a name or a handle for a thing. Labels include:

- Titles & headings
- Navigation items
- Button labels
- Link text
- Index terms



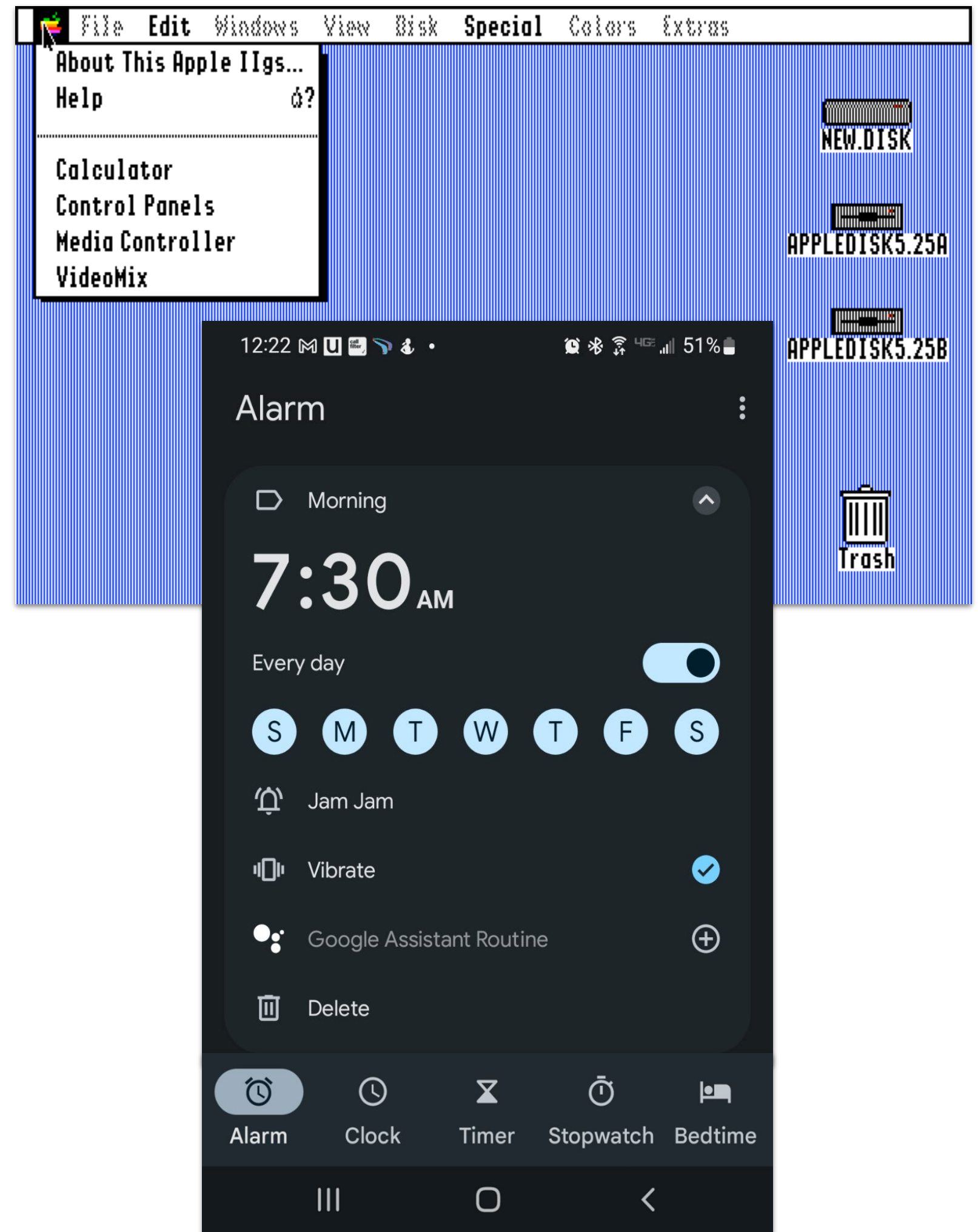
Graphics as Labels

Pros:

- Branding or visual appeal
- Less space
- Lower cognitive load IF they are...
 - Simple
 - Repetitive or obvious

Cons:

- Higher effort
- Impact on community editing





Elements

Labels

Vocabulary

Search

Navigation

Metadata

Style

- Consistent terms & spelling
 - "Data view" vs "Data-view" vs "Dataview" vs "DataVu"...
 - What terms are preferred by users and the industry?
- Build synonyms & preferred terms into the search



Elements

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You might have to design the search.

Features of some search systems:

- Autocomplete, booleans, filters/facets
- Synonyms, spelling variations
- Weighting options
- Keywords, tags, zones
- Topic-based search
- Personalized results
- Knowledge cards

Overview

Theodore Roosevelt Jr. was the 26th president of the United States, serving from 1901 to 1909. Previously serving six months as vice president under William McKinley, Roosevelt became president after McKinley's assassination in 1901.

[Wikipedia](#)

Born	October 27, 1858, Theodore Roosevelt Birthplace National Historic Site , New York, NY
Died	January 6, 1919 (age 60 years), Sagamore Hill National Historic Site , Cove Neck, NY
Party	Republican Party
Vice president	Charles Warren Fairbanks (1905–1909)
Children	Theodore Roosevelt Jr. , Alice Roosevelt Longworth · See more
Spouse	Edith Kermit Carow Roosevelt (m. 1886–1919), Alice Hathaway Lee Roosevelt (m. 1880–1884)



Elements

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Search vs Navigation

- **Search or navigation?**

Maybe users search for a general thing, then navigate within it.

- **Good navigation:**

- Tells people where they are
- Helps them find things they might not have searched for

AI can help with this, especially if you have good metadata.

Design tips

- Use a **card sorting** exercise to see how a typical user would arrange the site.
- After the site is up, use logs to understand user behavior patterns

Elements

Labels

Vocabulary

Search

Navigation

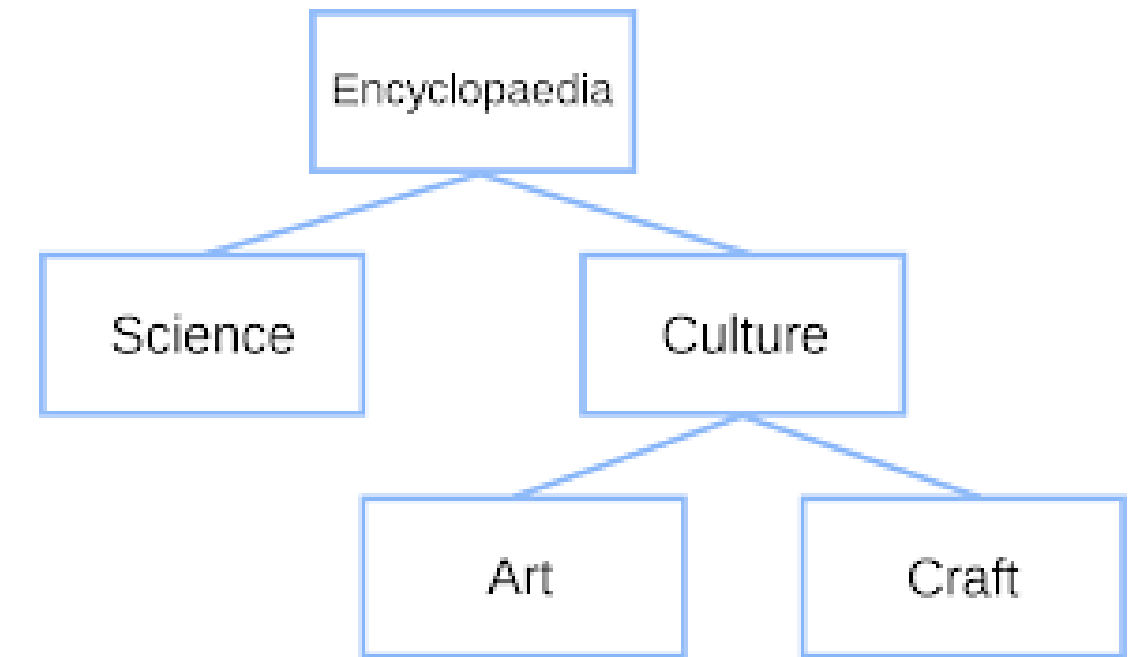
Metadata

Style

We tend to imagine a hierarchy, in which every item has 1 parent and 0 or more children.

Alternatives include heterarchy, polyhierarchy, and web.

In a polyhierarchy, there are multiple ways to categorize & access the information.



Personas & Paths

- Persona = role & use-case
 - Different reading paths for different personas
-
- Engineer? PM? Designer? New hire?
 - Taking a day to learn something, or rushing to solve a midnight crisis?





Elements

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"Data about data"

- Examples: creation date, author, type, purpose, audience, topic, keywords, description, other tags

Metadata enables:

- Polyhierarchy
- Dynamic navigation, e.g., a "What's New" list
- Filtering / facets
- Recommendations



Elements

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Visual structure!

Clear, consistent use of:

- Font styling
- Color scheme
- Page templates
- Headings, bullets, tables
- Diagram style
- Visual rhythm
- Etc.

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Previous editions of the book delved into the subject of information architecture as a career path. We have eschewed these discussions in the fourth edition in favor of treating information architecture as an area of practice. You do not need to have the words “information architect” on your business card in order to benefit from the ideas in this book.

Conventions Used in This Book

The following typographical conventions are used in this book:

Italic

Indicates new terms, URLs, email addresses, filenames, and file extensions.

Constant width

Used for program listings, as well as within paragraphs to refer to program elements such as variable or function names, databases, data types, environment variables, statements, and keywords.



This element signifies a general note.

Contacting the Authors

Please direct all suggestions, kudos, flames, and other assorted comments to us via email:

- Peter Morville, Semantic Studios (morville@semanticstudios.com)
- Lou Rosenfeld, Louis Rosenfeld LLC (lou@louisrosenfeld.com)
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Topics

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Topics

- Defining IA
- Elements
- **Process**

- **Research**
- **Strategy**
 - Proposal & Plan
 - Presentation
 - Politics
- **Implementation**



Recap

Defining IA

- Organizing
- Find & Use
- Context
- Sustainability

Elements

- Labels & Terms
- Search & Nav
- Metadata
- Style

Process

- Research
- Strategy
- Implementation

Great Engineering

- Valliere cannon (1730)
 - Beautiful, heavy, must be sent back to factory for expert repair
- Gribeauval cannon (1760)
 - Plain, lighter, modular, parts can be swapped in the field
 - Loved by Napoleon



Great Architecture

This unique, interesting building was:

- Expensive to build
- Hard to maintain
- Difficult to modify or expand



Great Architecture

These boring buildings were modular, maintainable, & expandable.

(Same 2 buildings, 136 years apart.)



New Orleans, 1857



The same two buildings, 1993

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Information Architecture Resources

Information Architecture

- [*How to Make Sense of Any Mess*](#) (free book) and the [IA Heuristics poster](#) by Abby Covert
- [Information Architecture](#) (Wikipedia)
- [*Information Architecture for the Web and Beyond*](#) (O'Reilly)
- [*Every Page Is Page One*](#) by Mark Baker
- [Good article on polyhierarchy and findability in IA](#)
- [Doc Training](#) (related Doc Eng guides)
- [Write & Organize](#) section (WTFE wiki)
- [World IA Day talks](#)
- [IAC conferences](#)

Crowdsourcing Documentation

- [Wikipatterns](#) (site & book) by Stewart Mader
- [*Conversation & Community*](#) by [Anne Gentle](#)

Architecture

- [*How Buildings Learn: What Happens After They're Built*](#) by Stewart Brand (or see the [BBC television series](#))